

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Ragozin, Vienna, Tarrasch, and Semi-Tarrasch

Pins, central gambits, isolated pawns, and active-piece solutions

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH	20

01. Ragozin Exchange Structure



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

01. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

02. Ragozin Exchange Structure



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

02. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

03. Ragozin Exchange Structure



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

03. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

04. Ragozin Qa4 Check



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd2 and a3 ideas to improve while challenging Bb4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black blocks the check and increases d4 pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

04. Decision Framework

Ragozin Qa4 Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ gains information, while Bd2 and Bd3 complete development without letting the queen become the center of attention.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.
TRADE FILTER	A bishop trade on b4 is useful when it improves development or pawn structure; avoid chasing the bishop for its own sake.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the information gained by Qa4+ to choose the structure, then centralize the rooks and stop moving the queen repeatedly. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

05. Ragozin Qa4 Check



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd2 and a3 ideas to improve while challenging Bb4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black blocks the check and increases d4 pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

05. Decision Framework

Ragozin Qa4 Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ gains information, while Bd2 and Bd3 complete development without letting the queen become the center of attention.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.
TRADE FILTER	A bishop trade on b4 is useful when it improves development or pawn structure; avoid chasing the bishop for its own sake.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the information gained by Qa4+ to choose the structure, then centralize the rooks and stop moving the queen repeatedly. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

06. Ragozin Qa4 Check



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd2 and a3 ideas to improve while challenging Bb4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black blocks the check and increases d4 pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. Qa4+ Nc6 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd2 Re8 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

06. Decision Framework

Ragozin Qa4 Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Qa4+ questions the pin immediately and encourages Black to commit the queenside knight before White chooses the structure.
PIECE JOB	Qa4+ gains information, while Bd2 and Bd3 complete development without letting the queen become the center of attention.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.
TRADE FILTER	A bishop trade on b4 is useful when it improves development or pawn structure; avoid chasing the bishop for its own sake.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Use the information gained by Qa4+ to choose the structure, then centralize the rooks and stop moving the queen repeatedly. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not spend several moves trying to trap the b4 bishop.

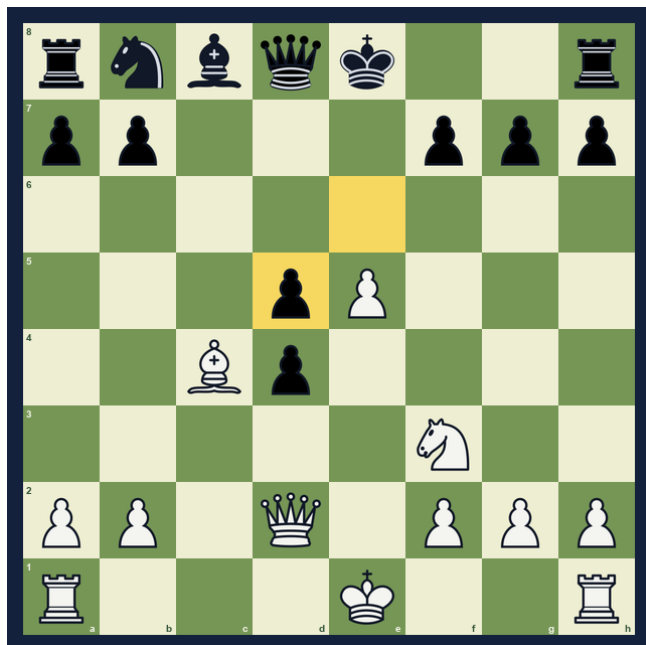
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Qa4+ is useful when the information gained is worth the queen move.

07. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly behind the e5 and d4 center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bb4: Black pins c3 and attacks the center indirectly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

07. Decision Framework

Vienna Variation Central Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns give space, but Bd2 and rapid castling are the pieces' urgent jobs while the c3-knight is pinned.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.
TRADE FILTER	Do not trade the pieces defending e4 and d4 without calculating the center; structural damage can be acceptable if open lines remain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Unpin, recover c4 when safe, open lines, and secure the king before trying to exploit the space advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.

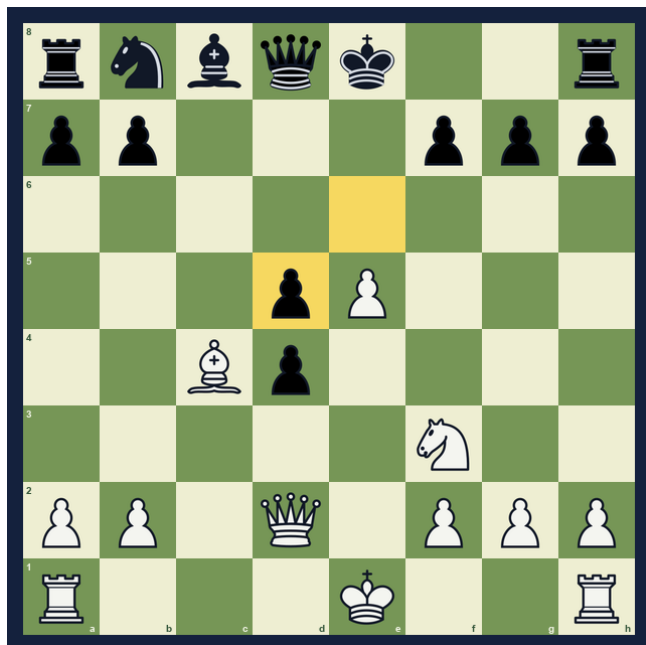
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

08. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly behind the e5 and d4 center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bb4: Black pins c3 and attacks the center indirectly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

08. Decision Framework

Vienna Variation Central Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns give space, but Bd2 and rapid castling are the pieces' urgent jobs while the c3-knight is pinned.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.
TRADE FILTER	Do not trade the pieces defending e4 and d4 without calculating the center; structural damage can be acceptable if open lines remain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Unpin, recover c4 when safe, open lines, and secure the king before trying to exploit the space advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.

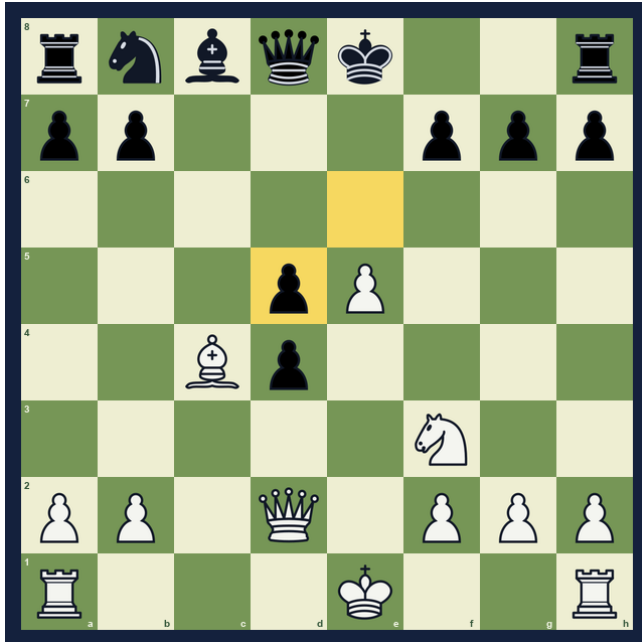
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

09. Vienna Variation Central Gambit



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly behind the e5 and d4 center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Bb4: Black pins c3 and attacks the center indirectly.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 dxc4 5. e4 Bb4 6. e5 Nd5 7. Bd2 c5 8. Bxc4 cxd4 9. Nxd5 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 exd5

MEMORY RULE

Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

09. Decision Framework

Vienna Variation Central Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black takes c4 and pins the knight; White builds e4-e5 and accepts tactical complications for space and development.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawns give space, but Bd2 and rapid castling are the pieces' urgent jobs while the c3-knight is pinned.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.
TRADE FILTER	Do not trade the pieces defending e4 and d4 without calculating the center; structural damage can be acceptable if open lines remain.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Unpin, recover c4 when safe, open lines, and secure the king before trying to exploit the space advantage. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not play the Vienna without understanding the c3 pin.

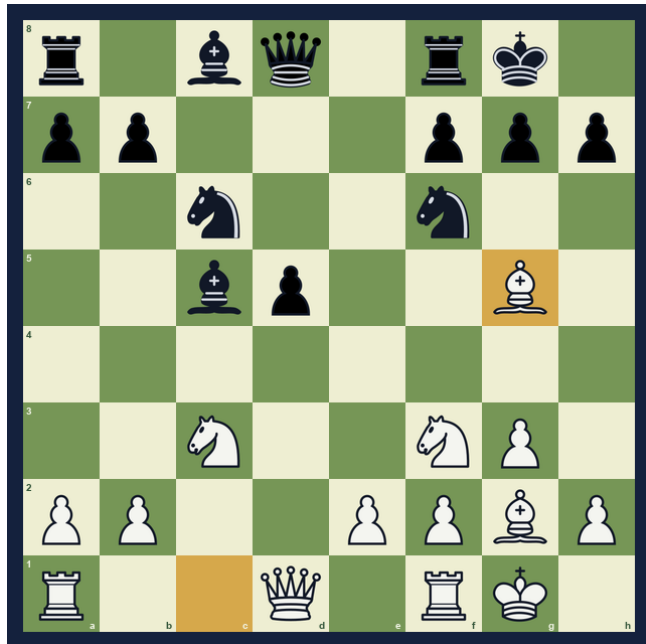
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Vienna theory is center, unpin, development-recover c4 only after those.

10. Tarrasch Defense Main Line



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Control d4 and place a piece in front of the isolated pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black supports d4 and active development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

10. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Defense Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.
PIECE JOB	White's g2-bishop pressures d5 while the other pieces blockade and attack Black's isolated queen's pawn.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade active Black pieces-especially those supporting d4 or e4-but keep enough pieces to attack the isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Blockade first, exchange attackers second, then convert the fixed d-pawn or superior minor-piece endgame. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.

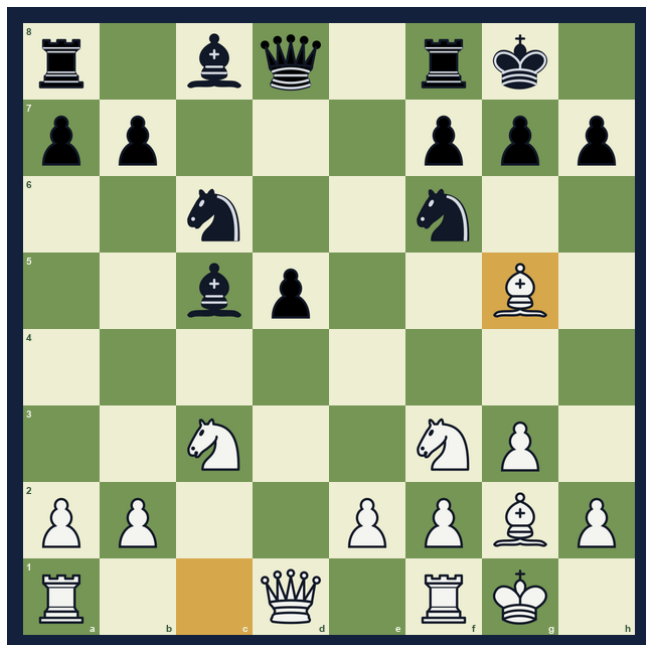
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

11. Tarrasch Defense Main Line



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Control d4 and place a piece in front of the isolated pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nc6: Black supports d4 and active development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

11. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Defense Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.
PIECE JOB	White's g2-bishop pressures d5 while the other pieces blockade and attack Black's isolated queen's pawn.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade active Black pieces-especially those supporting d4 or e4-but keep enough pieces to attack the isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Blockade first, exchange attackers second, then convert the fixed d-pawn or superior minor-piece endgame. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

PAGE 25



Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development;
White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce
Black's activity.

Control d4 and place a piece in front of the isolated pawn.

...Nc6: Black supports d4 and active development.

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

12. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Defense Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black accepts an isolated d-pawn for free development; White uses the fianchetto to pressure the center and reduce Black's activity.
PIECE JOB	White's g2-bishop pressures d5 while the other pieces blockade and attack Black's isolated queen's pawn.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade active Black pieces-especially those supporting d4 or e4-but keep enough pieces to attack the isolated pawn.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Blockade first, exchange attackers second, then convert the fixed d-pawn or superior minor-piece endgame. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not attack d5 with every piece while Black attacks your king.

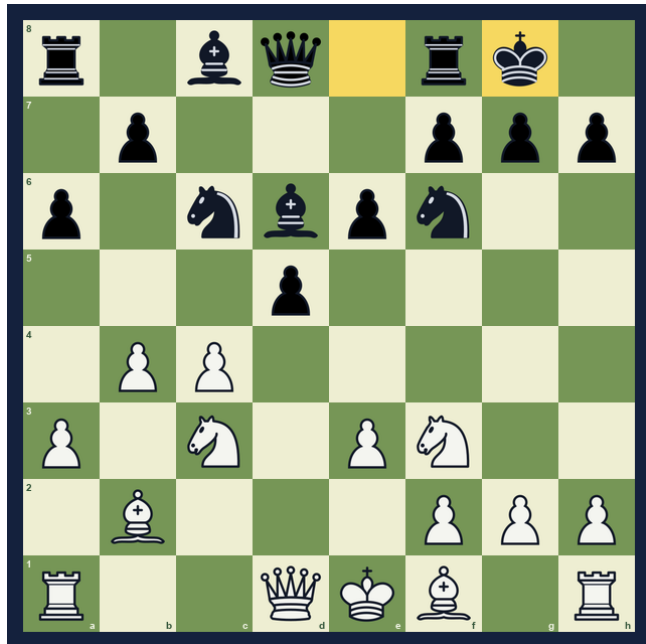
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against the Tarrasch, reduce activity first; the isolated pawn weakens later.

13. Tarrasch with e3 and a3



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, a3, and b4 without neglecting the king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nf6-Nc6: Black develops pressure on d4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

13. Decision Framework

Tarrasch with e3 and a3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.
PIECE JOB	a3 and b4 gain queenside space with tempo, but the central pieces must remain ready for ...dxc4 and ...e5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the active c5-bishop when the gain of queenside space leaves Black with a less useful minor piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Gain the tempo with b4, finish Bb2 and castling, then connect the queenside space to central pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.

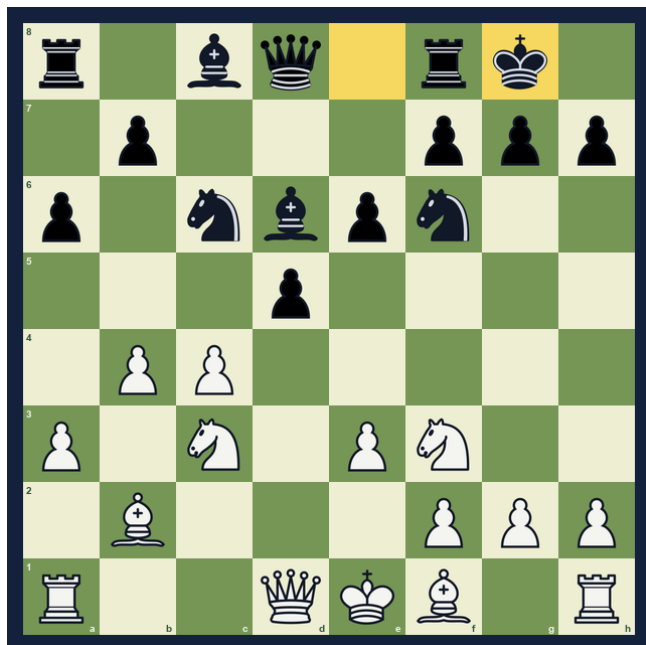
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

14. Tarrasch with e3 and a3



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, a3, and b4 without neglecting the king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nf6-Nc6: Black develops pressure on d4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

14. Decision Framework

Tarrasch with e3 and a3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.
PIECE JOB	a3 and b4 gain queenside space with tempo, but the central pieces must remain ready for ...dxc4 and ...e5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the active c5-bishop when the gain of queenside space leaves Black with a less useful minor piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Gain the tempo with b4, finish Bb2 and castling, then connect the queenside space to central pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.

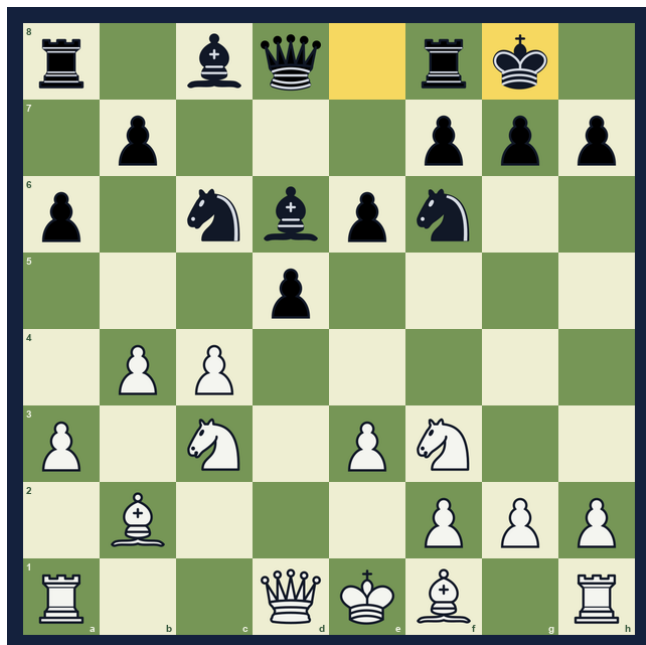
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

15. Tarrasch with e3 and a3



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3, a3, and b4 without neglecting the king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nf6-Nc6: Black develops pressure on d4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

15. Decision Framework

Tarrasch with e3 and a3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	White keeps central tension, develops classically, and uses a3-b4 to gain queenside time against Black's active bishop.
PIECE JOB	a3 and b4 gain queenside space with tempo, but the central pieces must remain ready for ...dxc4 and ...e5.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the active c5-bishop when the gain of queenside space leaves Black with a less useful minor piece.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Gain the tempo with b4, finish Bb2 and castling, then connect the queenside space to central pressure. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not push b4 if e5 or d4 opens against the king.

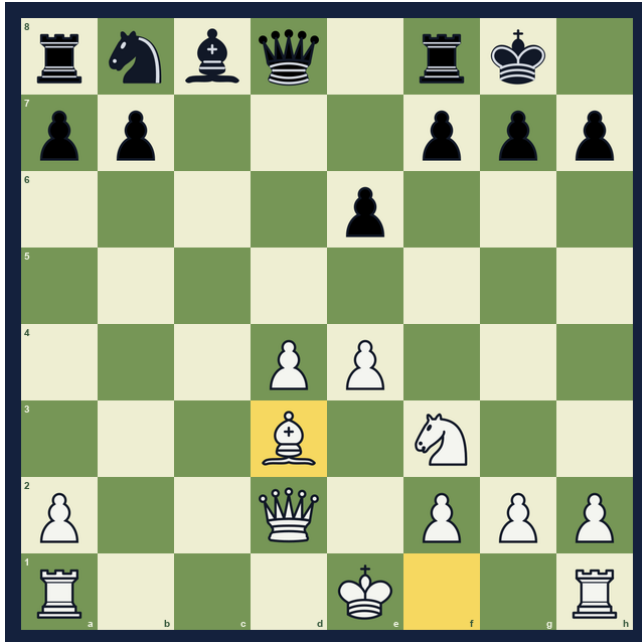
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: e3 setup: stabilize the center, gain one queenside tempo, then castle.

16. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and rooks to support e4 and d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxc3: Black damages White's pawn shape but gives the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

16. Decision Framework

Semi-Tarrasch Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawn duo needs quick piece support because Black has open lines and easy development.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not advance e5 before completing development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid mass exchanges that turn the central majority into a fixed target; trade when the pawn center can advance afterward.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, use the space to restrict Black, and transform the center before it becomes overextended. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not advance e5 before completing development.

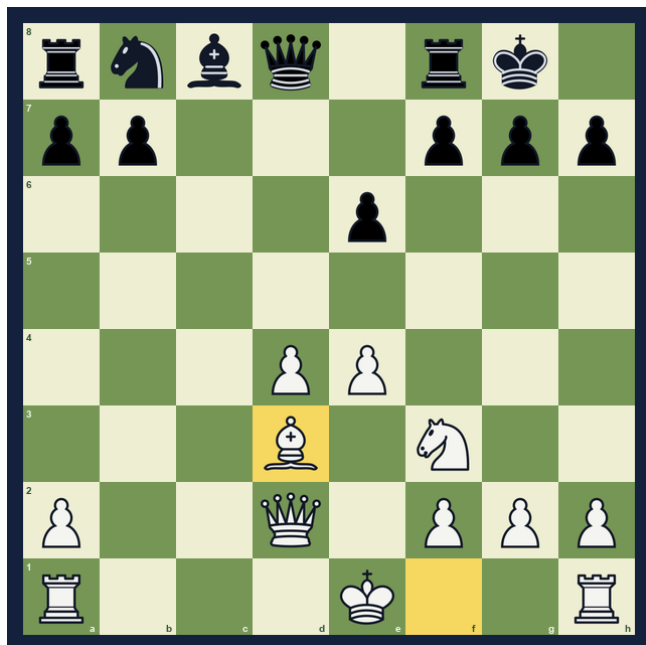
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

17. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and rooks to support e4 and d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxc3: Black damages White's pawn shape but gives the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

17. Decision Framework

Semi-Tarrasch Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawn duo needs quick piece support because Black has open lines and easy development.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not advance e5 before completing development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid mass exchanges that turn the central majority into a fixed target; trade when the pawn center can advance afterward.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, use the space to restrict Black, and transform the center before it becomes overextended. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not advance e5 before completing development.

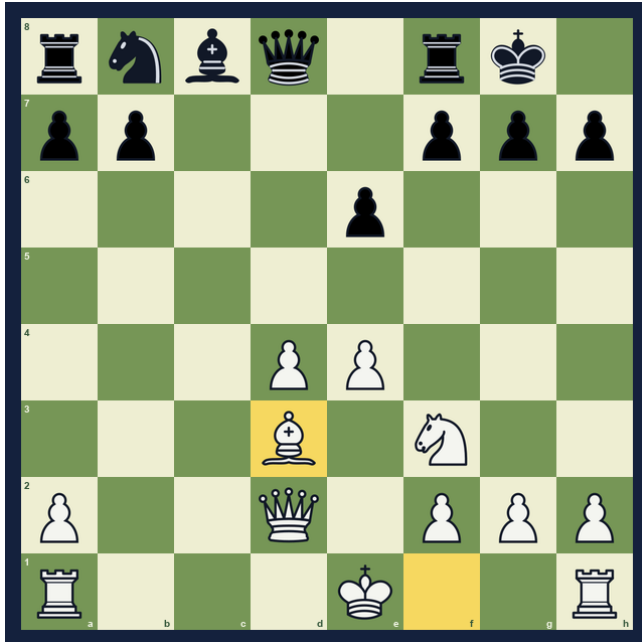
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

18. Semi-Tarrasch Main Line



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Bd3, O-O, and rooks to support e4 and d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...Nxc3: Black damages White's pawn shape but gives the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

18. Decision Framework

Semi-Tarrasch Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black recaptures on d5 with a knight, and the forcing exchanges give White a broad center and open bishop pair.
PIECE JOB	White's central pawn duo needs quick piece support because Black has open lines and easy development.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not advance e5 before completing development.
TRADE FILTER	Avoid mass exchanges that turn the central majority into a fixed target; trade when the pawn center can advance afterward.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Complete development, use the space to restrict Black, and transform the center before it becomes overextended. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not advance e5 before completing development.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Semi-Tarrasch: accept the pawn shape, keep the broad center, use the bishops.

19. Ragozin Exchange Structure - Move-Order Lab



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.

PRIMARY PLAN

Ragozin Exchange means Carlsbad structure plus immediate pressure on c3 and d4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

19. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure - Move-Order Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Reconstruct the line and name the first move-order fork.

20. Ragozin Exchange Structure - Plan Lab



RAGOZIN, VIENNA, AND TARRASCH

READ THE POSITION

Use development and rooks to prepare the central break.

PRIMARY PLAN

The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

...c5: Black attacks d4 and activates the queenside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

20. Decision Framework

Ragozin Exchange Structure - Plan Lab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Black's Bb4 adds pressure to c3 before White exchanges on d5, creating an active Carlsbad position with sharper piece play.
PIECE JOB	The pinned c3-knight changes the value of e4 and d5, so White's bishops and queen must carry more central responsibility.
TACTICAL WARNING	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.
TRADE FILTER	Trade the b4-bishop when it removes the pin on favorable terms, but do not spend tempi forcing an exchange that helps development.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Stabilize d4, castle and place rooks centrally before expanding; the Ragozin demands activity earlier than a quiet Carlsbad. Preserve the structural target or superior minor piece through simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Do not waste time removing Bb4 without a concrete reason.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: State White's plan, Black's best counterplay, and the piece that must improve first.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.